The Rite of the Fire Offering

Homavidhi · Toh 1255 · Derge Tengyur

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The Rite of the Fire Offering, known in Sanskrit as the Homavidhi and in Tibetan as Jinsek gi Choga, is Toh 1255 in the Tengyur, where it is found among the commentaries and ritual works on the tantras. It is a short funerary manual in the Hevajra tradition, opening with homage to Heruka, which its author says he composed out of love for the benefit of the dead, drawing on the root tantra because the rite is not set out in the tantra itself. It describes how the master prepares the corpse with mantras and nectar, lays out and consecrates the fire hearth, invites the fire god, and offers the body to Hevajra and his goddesses, before guiding the consciousness of the deceased along the five paths, making votive clay images from the bones, and dedicating the merit. Its colophon names the work the Rite of Cremation and attributes it to the master Kṛṣṇa, who translated it into Tibetan with Gö Lhetsé.

In the language of India: homa vidhi. In the language of Tibet: The Rite of the Fire Offering.

Homage to the Blessed One, glorious Heruka.

Whose eight faces are the storm clouds at the time of destruction,
whose feet are the four means of attracting, who is locked in embrace,
whose sixteen arms are the sixteen emptinesses:
to that dancer I bow and pay homage.
For the benefit of the dead,
although the rite does not appear in this tantra,
following the root tantra,
out of love I shall write it.

The master, endowed with the five mudrās, first bathes the corpse and anoints it with scents mixed with nectar. On the heart of the corpse he should place the heart mantra of his own deity. If there is no deity, he should place the heart mantra of Amitābha or of the goddess Caṇḍālī. At the throat the heart mantra, at the heart the near-heart mantra; at the crown oṃ, at the throat āḥ, at the heart hūṃ, at the navel svā, and on the two feet hā should be placed. The root tantra says:

Place the five families that bless body and speech.
Your own deity, or another, will do:
place its heart mantra at the heart.
Purify by bathing; anoint with nectar.

Then tie a dhāraṇī cord at the heart of the corpse and place it in a box. Generate yourself as the maṇḍala of the deity, hold the dhāraṇī cord, and do the mantra recitation. From time to time anoint it with nectar. Interweave the root mantra with the name, and perform a fire offering of sesame. With recitation, make amends for faults, and make offerings and praises. At the end, request the deities to depart. This is the preliminary approach.

Then purifying a pleasing site, taking possession of the ground, casting the torma, worshiping the earth goddess Pṛthivī, praising her, and all the rest should be learned from the maṇḍala rite. That is taking possession of the ground. From the preparatory consecration of the earth goddess up to the preparatory consecration, it is the same as the maṇḍala rite. Then the preparatory consecration of the fire offering should be performed and the torma cast. The preparatory consecration of the corpse is this: bathe it, anoint it with the five nectars mixed with sweet fragrance, and, after first summoning its consciousness, generate it as the deity yourself; then do everything from the confession of wrongdoing up to the generation of the mind of awakening. Then make offerings to the deities of the maṇḍala, praise them, request their attention, make aspirations, and ask their forbearance. This is the rite of the preparatory stage.

Then raise the maṇḍala into the sky, anoint the ground with the five nectars, and lay out the lines according to the rite of the lines. Having performed the rite of the colors, draw as follows. In the center of the hearth draw an eight-petaled lotus. At the center of the lotus draw a skull cup and a curved knife. On the petals draw the emblems of the goddesses. On the rim make a vajra fence. Outside the rim, cut notched corners. Then draw the doors, the archways and so forth as appropriate. Then generate the maṇḍala, merge it with the deities above, and make offerings, praises and aspirations.

Then, with a bundle of kuśa grass, sprinkle the wood with water from the vase for all activities and dispel the obstructors. The stacking of the wood should be understood as appropriate. Spread a seat inside the hearth, and, after first summoning the consciousness, generate the corpse as the deity; perform the confession of wrongdoing and the rest. Cast the torma. Then kindle the fire

with a fan, saying:

Listen, and attend, child of good family!
On the firewood of the five aggregates
I kindle the fire of the Victors of the five families.
On the firewood of the five afflictions
I kindle the fire of the five ḍākinīs.
On the firewood of the five consciousnesses
I kindle the fire of the five wisdoms.
On the firewood of the four elements
I kindle the fire of the four goddesses.

With these words kindle the fire. Pour three oblations into the fire. Purify the fire, and generate the fire god from raṃ. Then invite the wisdom fire god, saying:

Come here, come here, supreme fire god,
sage, brahmin, three-eyed one!
Partake of the burnt oblations as your food,
and please be seated on the blazing seat.

Having said this, invite him with oṃ ehye mahābhūta deva ṛṣi aganye svāhā jaḥ hūṃ boṃ hoḥ, offer him rinsing water, merge the two inseparably, and worship him with the eight offerings.

Then perform the fire offering with the filling ladle and the pouring ladle. Offer three ladlefuls to the fire, and then offer in sequence. With oṃ vajra aganya svāhā offer the kindling sticks to his radiance. With oṃ aganye svāhā offer melted butter to his mouth. With oṃ sarva pābaṃ dahana vajrāya svāhā, sesame and white mustard seed to his hands. With oṃ sarva saṃpade svāhā, yogurt and cooked rice to his hands. With oṃ apratihata vajrāya svāhā, kuśa grass to the crown of his head. With oṃ vajra āyuśe svāhā, dūrvā grass to the crown of his head. With oṃ mahā vegāya svāhā, barley to his mouth. With oṃ mahā ghasmari svāhā, wheat to his mouth. With oṃ vajra vijāya svāhā, unhusked barley to his mouth. With oṃ mahā balāya svāhā, beans and black gram to his mouth. With oṃ vajra puṣṭaye svāhā, unhusked rice to his mouth. With oṃ mahā sri la a byi to svāhā offer nutmeg, taraka and bilva fruit to his mouth.

The liquid substances and the remaining substances to be burnt should be burnt with the fire god's own vidyā-mantra. All the liquid substances go to his mouth. All the woods, such as udumbara, are burnt by inserting each one's

own name between oṃ and svāhā. Of the offerings, scent goes to his heart, flowers to his head, incense to his blazing light, lamps in front of him, food to his mouth, cooling water to his mouth; the welcoming water and the rinsing water should be offered to his hands. Alternatively, all the substances to be burnt may be offered with this general mantra: oṃ vajra anala mahābhūta jvala sarva bhasmiṃ kuru sarva vighnāṃ hūṃ phaṭ so-and-so śāntiṃ kuru svāhā.

Then worship the fire god with the offerings and praise him:

Son of the supreme Brahmā, lord of the world,
king of the fire gods, empowered by Ṭakki,
who with supreme wisdom burns away all afflictions:
to the terrifying fire god I bow and offer praise.
Fire god of great splendor,
who fully grants every wish,
who abides on the ground, striving for the good of self and others:
to the supreme son of Brahmā I bow and pay homage.

Having praised him thus, then entrust him with his activity:

The great sage, the fire god,
swore an oath of his former commitment:
the mouth of the gods is fire;
the burnt offering abides in the fire.

Having entrusted him with his activity in these words, dissolve him into the form of the blazing fire.

Then, endowed with the yoga of Heruka with one face and two arms, invite the wisdom maṇḍala and worship it with outer and inner offerings. Praise it with the praise of the five realities, and merge it inseparably. Having made offerings and praises, then do the mantra recitation. After that, bless the feast and offer it to the deities as well. The yogins should burn it into the hūṃ at their hearts: this is the inner fire offering.

Then offer the fire offerings just as before. After that, purify wrongdoing with the heart mantra of your own deity or with the root mantra itself. Alternatively, recite oṃ āḥ hūṃ sarva pāpaṃ dahana vajraya so-and-so śāntiṃ kuru svāhā a hundred times, a thousand, ten thousand, or as many times as you can.

Those who do not perform the preparatory consecration should also generate the maṇḍala of the deity and perform the rites as before.

If you do not make the deceased into the deity, proceed as follows. Since this very Hevajra Tantra says, "all that is to be eaten, in the east, dust," the head, the heart and the sense organs are offered to Heruka. The brain goes to Gaurī. The spleen and liver go to Caurī. The urine, the bladder and the left channel go to Vetālī. The excrement, the stomach and the intestines go to Ghasmarī. The flesh goes to Pukkasī. The blood and the right channel go to Śavarī. The semen, the lymph and the central channel go to Caṇḍālī. The marrow and the fat go to Ḍombinī. The skin, which is the limbs of awakening, becomes the canopy. The bones, which are the four truths, become the firewood and the kindling sticks. The kidneys should be offered as a sight offering and continually.

Alternatively, the urine becomes the cooling water and the rinsing water. The blood becomes the welcoming water. The excrement becomes the incense. The entrails and the sense organs become the flowers. The brain and the lymph become the ointment. The great fat becomes the lamps. The flesh becomes the food. The skin becomes the canopy. The eight long bones become the music, such as flutes. The bones become the five mudrās. The hair of the head and body and so forth are offered as ornaments of the celestial palace. Then bless them all with the root mantra or with your own mantra, and offer them. As it is said:

The forms of the offerings, or their purified aspects,
should each be offered in its own essence.

Then worship with outer and inner offerings, praise with the praises, and purify the path:

The path of accumulation is like a mirage;
the second is like smoke;
the third you see as lightning;
the fourth is like a lamp;
the fifth, where all is empty,
is itself the ground of buddhahood.
In this very intermediate state of existence
may you bring the five paths to completion!

Having purified in this way, show the path:

By your bringing the five paths to completion,
the five aggregates themselves are the five buddhas,
the five afflictions are the five ḍākinīs,

the eight consciousnesses are the four wisdoms,
the four elements are the four goddesses.
Having cut off the stream of the wheel of existence,
you fully turn the wheel of Dharma,
and there is not even the name of saṃsāra.

Thus show the path.

The aspiration is this: "Through our worshiping Hevajra and his retinue with whatever offerings we have and with the fire offerings, may I, the patron, the deceased and all sentient beings purify the two obscurations, complete the two accumulations, and attain great unsurpassed awakening in this very life!" Having made this aspiration, make requests for the aims you desire. The request for activity to glorious Hevajra and his retinue is this: "For us and for the patrons, pacify every kind of illness, all that arises from wind, bile, phlegm and their combination! Free us from every kind of graha, the eighty thousand grahas! Please pacify all that arises from sudden adverse conditions!"

Then ask for forbearance: "Because I am a being of the degenerate age, the requisites are incomplete; and because I am a beginner, I have not gained mastery over my mind, and under the sway of dullness and agitation my practice is unclear. Please be greatly forbearing toward all lapses in the rite, all excesses and omissions." Then request the deities to depart.

Then offer the fire god whatever offerings you have and the remaining substances to be burnt, praise him with the verses beginning "Lord of the world," and make requests for the aims you desire: "Great sage, as I worship you with whatever offerings I have and with the fire offerings, please pacify everything adverse to us: every kind of illness, all grahas, and all sudden adverse conditions. Please make long life in this world, merit, glory, wealth and splendor increase like the waxing moon." Ask for forbearance: "Please be greatly forbearing toward whatever deficiency in my requisites and whatever lapses and errors in the rite there have been." Having said this, request him to depart.

Sweep up the maṇḍala and cast it into a great river. Then gather the bones and make clay votive images (tsatsas). Then, since it is said, "On the bones, the clothes or the name card make a tsatsa and confer empowerment," make the tsatsa according to its rite and confer empowerment on it in the maṇḍala: after first summoning the consciousness, make it into your own deity, perform

the confession of wrongdoing and the rest, and confer the five knowledge empowerments, with the empowerment of disciplined conduct as the sixth. The vows should not be conferred, because although the consciousness has been fully caught, it has no sense faculties.

Whatever virtue I have amassed
by performing the rite of cremation,
by it may all the world
attain stainless wisdom.

The Rite of Cremation, composed by the master Kṛṣṇa, is complete. It was translated by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa and Gö Lhetsé.

Translator's Notes

• The title's Sanskrit is given as spelled (homa vidhi, "rite of the fire offering"). In the opening verse the consort is not named; "locked in embrace" renders 'khyud. "With recitation, make amends for faults" interprets the terse bzlas pas skyon mchod bstod bya. "Raise the maṇḍala into the sky" refers to the deities generated earlier being lifted up while the hearth is drawn, then merged back ("the deities above"). "Ṭakki" (ṭakki) is left as transliterated; it may refer to the wrathful deity Ṭakkirāja, but this is uncertain. "Taraka" is an unidentified offering substance left as written. The text's chogs is read as tshogs, "feast", which the context plainly requires. "So-and-so" renders the Tibetan che ge mo inside the general mantra, where the name of the deceased is inserted.
• The words cited from the Hevajra Tantra, "all that is to be eaten, in the east, dust" (bza' ba thams cad shar du rdul), are rendered literally; their exact sense as a scriptural warrant for the offering of the body parts is unclear. "Lymph" renders gzhungs pa, whose precise referent is uncertain. "Sight offering" renders spyan gzigs. The colophon gives the work's title as "Rite of Cremation" (literally "rite of burning the corpse"), though the opening calls it the Rite of the Fire Offering. The author and translator nag po is given as Kṛṣṇa (Kṛṣṇācārya).

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.